

Fifteen Things to Do to Be a Great Democratic Candidate and Legislator

by Lew Toulmin, PhD, FRGS

Here are 15 things you could do to be an effective, responsive and even great Democratic candidate and legislator. Many of these cannot be done quickly, but they could all be worked on as part of your daily routine. The items are:

1. Develop a Farleyfile
2. Develop your memory for faces, names, facts and figures
3. Read and use Rachel Bitecofer's 2024 book *Hit 'Em Where it Hurts*
4. Learn "Freakonomics"
5. Recruit a great team
6. Don't promise to do things unless you really will do them
7. Keep a list of "To Dos"
8. Acknowledge receipt of all important texts, emails, letters and other comms
9. Send out thank you letters to all donors and helpful persons
10. Create a volunteer letter writing campaign that operates 365 days a year
11. Use yard signs and billboards
12. Employ text banks to GOTV
13. Bring in out-of-district volunteer teams
14. Pay attention to minority segments
15. Develop deep expertise in several issue areas.

1. Develop a Farleyfile

James Farley was the campaign manager for President Franklin Delano Roosevelt, Chairman of the Democratic National Committee, and Postmaster-General of the US. For FDR he developed a paper-based file of all the people FDR and Farley met, including their names, when they met, the names of family members, the issues and other items they discussed, contact information, party affiliation, hobbies, favorite food and drink, etc.

Today this personal list can easily be supplemented with other information obtained through public sources. Of course a computer program can be used to store the information, business cards can be scanned, and contact information quickly exchanged via smart phone. And the file can be expanded to include persons that you interact with via email, Zoom, text, Slack, etc. and to add modern concerns such as food allergies, vegan/vegetarian preference if any, etc. Note that your file should be encrypted and carefully protected.

One possible computer-based Farley file software you might consider include the "notes"

section of an iPhone – but this may not be adequate for long term extensive use. Monday.com customer relationship management (CRM) software and similar packages offer contact management, project management, team management, customer on-boarding and other elements.

Obtaining advice on this matter from staff at the Democratic Party, Emily's List and other support organizations is recommended.

2. Develop your memory for faces, names, facts and figures

Decades ago it was an accomplishment for teenagers to memorize 100 digits of Pi (remember 3.1416....?). Currently the Guinness world record is correctly reciting **70,000 digits of Pi**, in 10 hours, while blindfolded! The record holder is 25-year-old Rajveer Meena of India, who achieved this feat in 2015.

You may not need to recite digits of Pi, but any politician should be good at remembering faces, names and information. The current Guinness world record for putting names to faces and correctly spelling (often quite difficult) names is 218 faces/names studied for 15 minutes, with 35 minutes to recall as many as possible. World Memory Champion Emma Alam, now 22, set the record in December 2020. She is from Karachi, Pakistan.

Memory Champion Yanjaa Wintersoul of Mongolia learned 3000 words of Brazilian Portuguese in just three weeks. (See: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9pCCbkYGJvg>) She has used memory techniques to learn a whopping 14 languages, including English, Swedish and Chinese. In one week in 2018 Wintersoul, then 23, memorized all 328 pages of the IKEA catalog, including 4,818 images within the pictures on each page. She memorized a random deck of 52 cards in a record 22.03 seconds, and is one of only 22 certified Grandmasters of Memory in the world.

None of these “memory athletes” are abnormal people – they are just ordinary people who have learned special techniques, usually involving visual clues, which are available to anyone willing to devote some serious study, perhaps 5 hours per week for 7 or 8 weeks to get to a useful level. The techniques include the “Memory Palace” for recalling lists of items, creating your own mental Farleyfile on people, or remembering issues or talking points; prepared lists of clues for recalling names, converting them to visual clues, and mentally attaching these clues to their faces; and converting numbers such as dates (or digits of Pi!) into recallable visual images and stories.

These memory techniques are excellent for learning issues, facts, dates, speeches, poetry, quotes, important study items such as the Periodic Table of Elements or all the bones in the body, foreign language vocabulary, test preparation, book summaries, debating points, etc., etc.

I recommend beginning by doing a quick review of the page on my website of “Memory Systems” – this includes a dozen short paragraphs summarizing the history and functioning of systems used by memory athletes. See: <http://www.themosttraveled.com/memory.html>

Second, read Joshua Foer’s excellent book *Moonwalking with Einstein*. He was a journalist who attended a competition for memory athletes as an observer, got hooked, and became the US National Memory Champion.

Next I suggest taking the short online course offered by Memory Champion Yanjaa Wintersoul, at: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=McpzERHzJVU>. The cost is \$109 but discounts are available.

Then I recommend Ron White’s *Black Belt in Memory* course, on-line. He was the US Memory Champion in 2009 and 2010. This course is more in-depth, and took me about 40 hours to complete, and another 50 hours of practice to be able to recall 100 names and faces. The cost is \$194.

3. Read and use Rachel Bitecofer’s 2024 book *Hit ‘Em Where it Hurts*

Bitecofer is called “The Election Whisperer” for correctly forecasting recent national elections that were mis-called by the big four polling houses. She asserts that Republicans are much better than Democrats at messaging, developing wedge issues, branding, and developing “shiny object” distractions. She says we are more “policy wonks” who don’t really understand the tribalism of the modern electorate, and who often don’t emphasize our pride in being Democrats. She says that voters are “rough clay” who are mostly uninformed and need to be educated, that “negative partisanship” (motivating voters by showing why they should dislike the other side) is key to winning today, that supposed “swing voters” are mostly quite predictable, that “personalization” of messaging is key, that “campaigns are now 365/7/24,” and that all campaign information should pass the “message-in-a-glance 10-second test.” She gives numerous excellent tips and no-holds-barred strategies useful for Democratic political candidates at every level.

I would add that from Russia to the Republicans, our opponents are very vigorous (if often ham-handed) at information warfare. And it is warfare. We need to stop bringing a glass of white wine and a slice of brie to a gunfight.

We also need to understand why rural MAGA Republican voters are so wedded to their cult. They are sick of having their main streets boarded up, their jobs shipped overseas, their wages cut in half, being called “deplorables,” their desire for rural agency and control being ignored by “fly-over” bi-coastal, elitist experts, and the perceived lack of respect for their rural values and lifestyles. See James Joyner’s April 2024 article on rural voters at: <https://www.outsidethebeltway.com/its-not-rage-its-resentment/>

We Democrats need to get back those rural, now-red counties, by really understanding and listening to those rural voters.

4. Learn “Freakonomics”

“Freakonomics” is a school of economics, social engineering and political thought and analysis developed by award-winning Steven Levitt, Professor of Economics at the University of Chicago, and journalist Stephen Dubner. Their work focuses on studying and solving social and economic problems, using principles such as: understanding incentives and how they work and can be gamed; knowing what to measure; the conventional wisdom is almost always wrong; correlation is not causality; thinking small not big by “nibbling away at big problems;” and using “natural experiments” to understand what is really going on.

They are famous for discovering and arguing that one major reason that US crime rates dropped dramatically 18-20 years after abortion was legalized, was that many fewer unwanted babies were born into poor and difficult environments, and hence the cohort of youth 18 years later were happier, healthier, and less inclined to commit crimes. Political, judicial and policing changes had relatively little impact, compared to abortion. The three relevant books are *Freakonomics*, *SuperFreakonomics*, and *Think Like a Freak*. Their ideas are relevant and important to any political candidate, legislator or government administrator.

Using the Freakonomics approach, I would argue that the supposed current immigration “crisis” in the US is largely a matter of economics, not political border enforcement tactics or governmental policy. Now that unemployment in the US is approaching a 50-year low (hurrah!) at about 3.7% (and 3.0% of that is what labor economists call “frictional unemployment” (people switching jobs and taking a few weeks off) – hence **real unemployment is actually 0.7%!**), the economy is roaring, and job vacancies are high, the word is out. Migrants are flooding in, to fill those jobs and send those remittances back home to their families. (And we need those jobs to be filled.) When unemployment is high and jobs are scarce, potential migrants get the word, and stay home in droves. Duh!

This is all incredibly obvious and statistically provable, but virtually no politicians or commentators ever even mention it. Any new policy will need to address these facts, and treat immigration in a systemic and economically sensible way.

5. Recruit a great team

Any great candidate must have a great team, paid or unpaid. The team should be diverse (gender-wise and racial/ethnically), trustworthy, discreet, understanding of operational security (OPSEC), respectful of lines of authority within the campaign, focused on the prize of winning -- not on single issues, and very energetic.

Ideally the team should meet early every morning briefly in-person or via Zoom during the height of the campaign, report on issues encountered the day before, get assignments, and get going.

6. Don't promise to do things unless you really will do them

A common modern habit is to casually promise at the end of a conversation to do some favor, forward some information, or undertake some task. Eighty percent of the time these things don't happen – this is just a means of social lubrication and showing you care about the other person.

As a political candidate and/or office holder, don't do this. A promise from an important person like you is remembered, and resented if it doesn't happen. People, even friends and supporters, are judging you all the time. So, if you really want to email a document, make a commitment, do a favor, or whatever, WRITE IT DOWN and DO IT. Then the other person will think, "Oh my God, a politician who actually kept his/her word! Amazing!"

7. Keep a list of "To Dos"

Keep an ongoing list of "to dos" and check them off. Delegate if necessary but check and double-check that the task was actually done. (In telecommunications engineering the goal is always "The Five Nines" – meaning 99.999% reliability. In modern project management, delegation, social engineering, customer relationship management and economic regulation, my estimate is that we are in the range of "The Five Twos" – meaning only 22.222% reliability!)

Incorporate items into the "to dos" from the "promises" list immediately above. Use a notebook or a computerized list.

8. Acknowledge receipt of all important texts, emails, letters and other comms

Keep friends, supporters, staffers and others "warm" and confident in you by acknowledging receipt of all important information received via phone, email, text, Slack etc. I estimate that about 5% or more of emails just disappear due to over-active filtering by transiting ISPs, while WarmupInbox.com estimates that up to 20% of emails don't make it into people's inboxes or even spam folders! And many people are so overwhelmed with email, text and phone solicitations that important communications are often missed or deleted.

So, when you get something useful from a person you value, immediately acknowledge receipt, even if it is just something like, "Cool!" or "Thanks!" or the World War II standard message: "Roger, Wilco" (meaning "message received" and "will comply with your stated directions").

9. Send out thank you letters to all donors and helpful persons

This is self-explanatory.

10. Create a volunteer letter writing campaign that operates 365 days a year

As Bitecofer states, we are now in a full-time campaign era. MSNBC host Lawrence O'Donnell made a similar statement recently, when he asserted that, "now in February 2024 we are not in the beginning of the Biden Presidential campaign. We are in year FOUR of the Biden campaign, not early in year one. Anyone who doesn't understand this doesn't understand American politics."

One way to work on this is to develop a 365/year letter writing campaign. Such a campaign could be modeled on the Vote Forward approach. (See VoteFwd.org) This involves getting volunteers to write partially pre-printed and partially hand-written letters, addressed to registered voters in the candidate's district. The return address is a PO box in the relevant district, and the letters are posted in the district or from outside if the postmark does not reveal the location.

These letters urge Democratic or Dem-leaning voters to get out to vote, and can explicitly mention the candidate, or just urge voting as an important civic duty. The letters are written over many months, then are mailed all at once, about 8-15 days before the crucial election. Vote Forward has empirical evidence from several studies and elections that this technique increases Democratic voter turnout.

11. Use yard signs and billboards

Many Democratic consultants look down on yard signs and billboards and discourage their use. This is a major mistake. My wife and I easily predicted months in advance that Hillary Clinton would lose to Donald Trump in 2016. We knew this because we are snowbirds and take a different route each year from Maryland to Alabama and back. That year we counted over 2000 Trump signs on our route, and only 3 Hillary signs. She was doomed.

Signs matter. They are an excellent indication of enthusiasm and dislike of the opponent (a great motivator, per Bitecofer), and they persuade others to join the team. (Peer pressure is a tremendous motivator, too.)

A terrific tactic with signs would be to have many signs appear all at once, on a crucial day (e.g. July 4, or Flag Day, or the day after your opponent barely survives a grueling primary). Then send out a press release or have a story planted on "Where the heck did all these signs come from, all at once?"

Similarly, billboards can have a high impact with many "impressions," especially if they have a memorable message. For example, if there is an on-going major traffic jam in your district, how about a billboard(s) right there, saying something like this, "Republicans promised to solve this traffic jam for four years, but did nothing. Democrats actually passed a bill (over

Republican opposition) and now a solution is in sight – but Republicans are claiming credit! If you enjoy sitting in a traffic jam, vote Republican. If not, vote for Democrats!”

Billboards, like TV ads, may be cheaper if locked in months in advance – and this can lock out your opponent from securing key, high-traffic locations.

12. Employ text banks to GOTV

Door-knocking and phone banking are vital, but their “hit rates” are low, since many people are not home and don’t answer calls from phone numbers they don’t recognize. (When I went door-knocking, my hit rate was only about 10 percent. Ditto for calling.) By contrast, texts have a hit rate in the 90-95% range, and even though the response rate (persons who actually respond with a reply text) is much lower, perhaps 10-15 percent in my experience. I am confident that almost everyone I text is reminded to get out and vote.

In 2022 I texted almost 200,000 voters in swing states, using software such as Hustle, Thru Text and Spoke, and by signing up with numerous groups. NextGeneration (NextGen) was the most efficient and organized. See: <https://www.mobilize.us/NextGen/>

For more details, see my August 2022 column at: <https://www.mymcmedia.org/blog-texting-and-virtual-travel-to-save-democracy/>

13. Bring in out-of-district volunteer teams

Some organizations can provide teams of volunteers who will show up in your district to register Dem voters early on, and then GOTV in that last crucial month. These teams will usually assist at no cost to you. Approach outfits such as Common Power in Washington State and other similar groups suggested by Run for Something, Emily’s List, etc.

14. Pay attention to minority segments

We Democrats claim to represent minority segments of our districts well, but in fact often ignore them when compared to Republicans. A case in point: Metro-Dade County (around Miami) is vital to winning in Florida, and the Venezuelan immigrant community there is vocal and powerful. Trump knew this and upon becoming President he immediately began wooing them with visits and photo ops and empty promises. National Democrats largely ignored this vital Venezuelan segment until shortly before the 2020 election, when it was far, far too late. Minority segments often have major policy needs and demands, but active listening and demonstrations of respect by policy makers and candidates can be just as important.

15. Develop deep expertise in several issue areas

Many legislators see themselves as placeholders, just voting the party line, and only developing a superficial knowledge of their committee assignments and other areas. Especially on the Republican side, they often turn the crucial function of legislative committee oversight into stupid, meaningless theatrics.

A great candidate and legislator works hard to develop a deep, evidence-based knowledge of several issues, by holding in-depth hearings, reading widely, publishing, interviewing citizens, key actors, victims, administrators, NGOs and volunteers, and commissioning objective studies of social problems. Such a person is much more likely to gain the respect of her/his colleagues, be a future candidate for substantive office in the executive branch, and (most importantly) be a truly useful servant to her/his constituents.

Excellent roles models could include Eleanor Roosevelt, who acted as the President's eyes and ears on a wide range of issues during WW II all over the world, inspecting factories, military bases, hospitals, Red Cross stations, kitchens, tent camps and other locations in the US, England, the New Hebrides, New Caledonia, New Zealand, Australia and even Guadalcanal in the South Pacific. She focused on inspecting the quality of the institutions, and on the status and issues of ordinary soldiers and citizens, especially women. She often changed her schedule or transport at the last minute, to make intentionally unannounced surprise visits. In her five-week trip through the South Pacific war zone, she made 17 stops and talked to an estimated 400,000 people! During her secret visit to Guadalcanal, her location there was bombed by the Japanese the day before and the day after she visited.

Modern role models might include Congresswoman Katie Porter, who uses her famous white board to vigorously oversee and question executive branch officials and company CEOs, and Congresswoman Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, who developed the Green New Deal plan that provides a road map for saving the planet.

Good luck!

(And as "The Few" RAF WW II pilots in the Battle of Britain were told when going after Nazi Luftwaffe fighters, "Good hunting!")

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